

Unicorn Anatomy

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Common DNA of \$1B+ AI firms

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Unicorn Anatomy examines the common characteristics of companies that reach a billion-dollar valuation — large markets, strong defensibility, exceptional teams and compounding advantages — to identify the DNA of breakout success.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A construct from venture analysis of high-valuation companies, building on Aileen Lee's coining of the term 'unicorn'.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

It was developed to identify recurring traits of breakout companies, while cautioning that valuation alone is not durability.

FIGURE 1 · UNICORN ANATOMY



Figure 1. A schematic of the Unicorn Anatomy as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

A company is assessed against the recurring traits; gaps indicate where durability must be strengthened.

WHEN IT IS USED

When assessing breakout potential and durability of AI ventures.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, investors and strategists.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It dissects what billion-dollar companies share, while warning that the valuation label is an output, not a strategy.

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SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Lee, A. (2013) 'Welcome to the unicorn club', TechCrunch.

Gornall, W. and Strebulaev, I.A. (2020) 'Squaring venture capital valuations with reality', Journal of Financial Economics, 135(1).